THE EMERGENCY MIND

Moderator Guide | Ranger Mastery Program - Day 6

A conversation about preparation, judgment, and teamwork under pressure.

Audience: Support Engineers, Rangers, Escalation Engineers, Technical Leads

Suggested duration: 90 minutes | 6-10 participants
Conversation only | No written activities

1. Top learnings and conversation purpose

RMP Day 6 | Week 2: Structure ambiguity. Explore performance under pressure through the RMP study guide summarizing Dr. Dan Dworkis's *The Emergency Mind*.

Learning objectives - through conversation, participants will:

- **Recognize the pressure context:** discuss how uncertainty, impact, and urgency can affect the use of knowledge.
- **Understand preparation:** consider how familiar procedures, resources, and role clarity support action before a crisis arrives.
- **Choose a useful next action:** explore focus and proportionate decisions without waiting for total certainty or rushing unsafely.
- **Use the team:** discuss how shared understanding, explicit requests, and accepted relief reduce avoidable load.
- **Learn and recover:** exchange ideas for constructive debriefs and moving out of crisis mode without abandoning continuity.

Expected outcome

Participants leave with a shared view of effective incident response as supported and learnable, not proof of innate toughness. They hear ways to connect preparation, clear next decisions, team resources, and review while respecting the organization's incident and safety procedures. There are **no written tasks, simulations, worksheets, tests, or required follow-up assignments**.

Suggested 90-minute conversation

Time	Conversation topic	Question at its heart
0-8	Welcome, objectives, and opening round	Where does this show up in our support work?
8-20	1. Knowing versus doing under pressure	Why can an engineer know the procedure and still find the first minutes of a major incident difficult?
20-32	2. Prepare before the incident	What can a support team settle in advance so the first incident minutes are not improvised?
32-44	3. The next useful action	When everything feels urgent, what helps us find the next useful and safe action?
44-56	4. Reduce load through the team	How can a team reduce the load on an engineer who is diagnosing, updating, and fielding questions at once?
56-68	5. Adapt without losing structure	What helps us notice that the original plan no longer fits the incident?
68-80	6. Debrief and leave crisis mode	What makes a post-incident conversation help people learn rather than defend themselves?
80-90	Key takeaways and lessons learned	What changed or expanded our thinking?

Use: a flexible route, not a questionnaire to finish. Open with one question and choose follow-ups as needed. Examples are conversation starters, not exercises. The six topics are original support adaptations, not a claimed sequence from the source.

2. Conversation: pressure and preparation

Topic 1 | Knowing versus doing under pressure - 8-20 min

Learning objective: Explore how pressure changes access to existing knowledge.

Open the conversation: *"Why can an engineer know the procedure and still find the first minutes of a major incident difficult?"*

Follow the conversation:

- What happens when uncertainty, customer impact, and time pressure arrive together?
- Which work behaviors suggest the team needs more clarity or support?
- How do we avoid treating a pressured response as a fixed personality trait?

If a concrete example helps: An experienced engineer joins a noisy bridge and starts collecting data before anyone confirms impact or roles. Ask: *What might make familiar knowledge harder to use in that moment?*

If the discussion drifts: *"Rather than judge who handles stress well, what conditions made the right action harder to take?"*

Learning point to draw out: Knowing the procedure and using it under pressure are different challenges. Preparation, work design, and team support matter.

Topic 2 | Prepare before the incident - 20-32 min

Learning objective: Discuss what makes a useful response easier to access.

Open the conversation: *"What can a support team settle in advance so the first incident minutes are not improvised?"*

Follow the conversation:

- Which roles, escalation routes, or access arrangements should already be clear?
- What makes a checklist or playbook usable rather than another document to search?
- What recurring preparation gap should leadership help remove?

If a concrete example helps: An on-call engineer knows whom to page but lacks approved diagnostic access. Ask: *What preparation would have removed that delay, and who owns making it available?*

If the discussion drifts: *"Instead of designing a whole new process, which preparation gap most affected the first useful action?"*

Learning point to draw out: Readiness includes people, access, tools, and shared expectations. Personal confidence cannot compensate for unavailable resources or unclear authority.

3. Conversation: action and team resources

Topic 3 | The next useful action - 32-44 min

Learning objective: Explore a bounded decision when the whole incident is not yet understood.

Open the conversation: *"When everything feels urgent, what helps us find the next useful and safe action?"*

Follow the conversation:

- What must we know immediately, and what can remain uncertain for now?
- When is the goal limiting impact rather than confirming root cause?
- What review or approval should still protect a high-risk action?

If a concrete example helps: Several symptoms emerge while the customer asks for an immediate fix. Ask: *How could the team clarify current impact, select an approved next step, and avoid competing uncoordinated changes?*

If the discussion drifts: *"We do not need the final fix here. What immediate decision would make the situation safer or clearer?"*

Learning point to draw out: A bounded next action can restore direction without pretending the whole problem is solved. Urgency does not cancel required safeguards.

Topic 4 | Reduce load through the team - 44-56 min

Learning objective: Connect clear roles and requests with better coordination.

Open the conversation: *"How can a team reduce the load on an engineer who is diagnosing, updating, and fielding questions at once?"*

Follow the conversation:

- What information should the bridge share so people are not reasoning from different pictures?
- How can an engineer ask for help without a vague appeal to everyone?
- What does accepted relief or a peer check look like during an active incident?

If a concrete example helps: Three groups ask the investigator for updates at the same time. Ask: *Could a named communication role and a shared status view help, and how would responsibilities be accepted?*

If the discussion drifts: *"Rather than ask someone to concentrate harder, what coordination could remove avoidable load?"*

Learning point to draw out: Team structure is a practical resource. Clear roles, focused requests, and accepted coverage support attention without hiding responsibility.

4. Conversation: adaptation and learning

Topic 5 | Adapt without losing structure - 56-68 min

Learning objective: Discuss updating the plan when evidence or impact changes.

Open the conversation: *"What helps us notice that the original plan no longer fits the incident?"*

Follow the conversation:

- How can we invite a contrary observation when the bridge is already committed to a theory?
- Which change should trigger a reassessment or a different decision-maker?
- How do we avoid both rigid procedure-following and uncontrolled improvisation?

If a concrete example helps: A mitigation seems to help briefly, then impact spreads to another region. Ask: *What should be rechecked, who needs the new picture, and how should the next decision be coordinated?*

If the discussion drifts: *"Let us focus on what changed and how the team would update its understanding, not defend the first plan."*

Learning point to draw out: Structure supports response, but new evidence can require a new plan. Make the change visible through the approved incident route.

Topic 6 | Debrief and leave crisis mode - 68-80 min

Learning objective: Explore constructive review and recovery after demanding work.

Open the conversation: *"What makes a post-incident conversation help people learn rather than defend themselves?"*

Follow the conversation:

- How do we distinguish hindsight from what the team could actually know at the time?
- Which improvement belongs in staffing, tooling, or procedure rather than personal resolve?
- What allows responders to hand over and disconnect when the immediate incident ends?

If a concrete example helps: An incident is stabilized, but engineers remain informally available for days because follow-up ownership is unclear. Ask: *What accepted handover and review structure would support both continuity and recovery?*

If the discussion drifts: *"We do not need personal stress disclosures. What work condition or learning opportunity should the team address?"*

Learning point to draw out: Review should examine decisions and conditions without blame. Clear follow-up ownership and appropriate relief help keep crisis mode from becoming the normal operating model.

5. Moderator's guide: keep it a conversation

Set the tone: opening eight minutes

Introduce the objectives and expected outcome. Say: *"This is a conversation, not an assessment. Different roles and regions will see this differently. Use fictional or anonymized work patterns, not customer details. You can pass, and I will make room for each voice."*

Use a short opening round: *"What becomes hardest to do well when a support incident suddenly becomes high-pressure? A phrase or short example is enough."* Invite everyone once, allowing about 20-30 seconds each. Do not solve each case. Name one or two shared themes, then move to Topic 1.

Make participation broad, not forced

Aim for **6-10 participants**. With a larger group, use more round tables or allow more time. Rotate the first voice, invite different roles and shifts, and allow silence for thought. Everyone receives a genuine invitation, not an obligation to disclose or defend their ability.

What you notice	A useful moderator phrase
The same people answer first	"Thank you. Before adding more, let us hear from someone who has not spoken on this topic."
A quieter participant has not had space	"Would you like to add a view from your role or shift? Passing is completely fine."
A speaker runs long	"Let me pause there to make room for others. What is the main point you would like us to take from that?"
The conversation becomes a detailed case review	"We do not need to replay every incident detail. What pressure, preparation, or coordination issue does it illustrate?"
A person or region is blamed	"Let us examine the work conditions and behaviors, not judge the person or team. What would help any engineer here?"
Participants disagree	"What information and resources were available then, and what would make the next decision clearer?"
Discussion moves to an unrelated issue	"That matters, but it takes us away from today's objective. Can we connect it to this question, or leave it for the appropriate channel?"
There is silence	"Take a moment. Would the fictional support example help? What might be difficult in that situation?"

Bridge between topics

Reflect neutrally: *"I am hearing [theme], with a different experience around [difference]. Have I understood? That connects to our next question about [next topic]."* Do not manufacture agreement. Skip optional follow-ups if time is short rather than rush the closing round.

Boundaries: arrange live-queue coverage and follow normal incident and safety procedures. No customer identifiers, raw logs, credentials, personal health disclosures, or live technical changes. Acknowledge sensitive personal concerns and offer the appropriate private support route; do not investigate them in the round table.

6. Close: key takeaways and lessons learned

Key takeaways to connect back to the objectives

- **Pressure changes the challenge.** Knowing what to do is not always the same as being able to do it readily.
- **Prepare the conditions.** Roles, access, usable procedures, and resources matter before the incident.
- **Choose the next safe action.** Do not confuse decisiveness with unsupported certainty or unapproved risk.
- **Use the team deliberately.** Shared understanding and explicit responsibilities reduce avoidable load.
- **Learn without blame and recover with continuity.** Follow-up ownership and relief are part of the response.

Lessons-learned conversation: minutes 80-87

Invite a brief closing round, with the option to pass: *"What is one idea you are taking away, or one colleague's perspective that changed or expanded your thinking?"* Keep contributions short so everyone has space. No writing or public commitment is required.

If helpful, ask: *"Where might this help in daily support work?"* or *"What still needs team or leadership support?"* Reflect actual participant insights, not anticipated outcomes.

Examples to help the moderator recognize learning

A participant might say...	Connection to the learning objective
"The access gap mattered more than individual confidence."	Preparation: make necessary resources available before pressure arrives.
"We needed one next decision, not a theory for every symptom."	Action: bound the immediate problem while coordinating risk.
"The incident ended, but the ownership uncertainty did not."	Recovery: make follow-up and accepted relief explicit.

Moderator wrap-up: minutes 87-90

Summarize two or three themes heard, acknowledge differences, and return to the objectives. Do not promise actions you cannot authorize.

Closing thought: *"Effective response is not a test of toughness. It is preparation, a clear next decision, and a team that helps people use what they know when pressure makes that harder."*

Source and adaptation note

Based on the RMP *The Emergency Mind - Study Guide & Training Summary*, summarizing Dr. Dan Dworkis's book. Contents and selected introductory/preparation sections reviewed November 2, 2026; the full book was not reviewed. Questions and examples are original support adaptations. This is general workplace discussion, not clinical advice or a replacement for incident procedures.

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